boards, courts and newspapers is particularly low, an enhanced reliance on mythology is the only way to preserve order.

MEASURING THE STRENGTH OF DEMOCRACIES

Strongmen who claim to represent the people may well rise to power through democratic means, and often rule behind a democratic facade. Rigged elections in which they win overwhelming majorities serve as proof of the mystical bond between the leader and the people. Consequently, to measure how democratic an information network is, we cannot use a simple yardstick like whether elections are being held regularly. In Putin's Russia, in Iran and even in North Korea elections are held like clockwork. Rather, we need to ask much more complex questions like 'What mechanisms prevent the central government from rigging the elections?' 'How safe is it for leading media outlets to criticise the government?' and 'How much authority does the centre appropriate to itself?' Democracy and dictatorship aren't binary opposites, but rather are on a continuum. To decide whether a network is closer to the democratic or the dictatorial end of the continuum, we need to understand how information flows in the network and what shapes the political conversation.

If one person dictates all the decisions, and even their closest advisers are terrified to voice a dissenting view, no conversation is taking place. Such a network is situated at the extreme dictatorial end of the spectrum. If nobody can voice unorthodox opinions publicly, but behind closed doors a small circle of party bosses or senior officials are able to freely express their views, then this is still a dictatorship, but it has taken a baby step in the direction of democracy. If 10 per cent of the population participate in the political conversation by airing their opinions, voting in fair elections and running for office, that may be considered a limited democracy, as was the case in many ancient city-states like Athens, or in the early days of the United States, when only wealthy white men had such political rights. As the percentage of people taking part in the conversation rises, so the network becomes more democratic.

The focus on conversations rather than elections raises a host of interesting questions. For example, *where* does that conversation take place? North Korea, for example, has the Mansudae Assembly Hall in